

Education Pathway Comparison

NAME _____ DATE _____ PERIOD _____

Compare three ways into an IT career. Pick one career for each column. Career 1 needs a certification only. Career 2 needs an associate degree plus a certification. Career 3 needs a bachelor's degree.

Use the Hats & Ladders app for the career, the CompTIA Career Roadmap for the certification, and the BLS website for the salary. Rough numbers are fine. Write the number you find, not a guess.

FIELD	CAREER 1: CERTIFICATION ONLY	CAREER 2: ASSOCIATE DEGREE + CERT	CAREER 3: BACHELOR'S DEGREE
Career Name			
Required Education			
Time to Complete			
Estimated Cost			
Median Salary (BLS)			

Where to find each number

- **Required Education:** the education indicator on the Hats & Ladders Hat profile.
- **Time to Complete:** months for a certification, 2 years for an associate degree, 4 years for a bachelor's degree.
- **Estimated Cost:** certifications run about \$200 to \$1,000. An associate degree at a community college runs about \$5,000 to \$15,000. A bachelor's degree runs \$40,000 and up.
- **Median Salary:** the BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook page for that job.

Think About It

1. Which path takes the LEAST time? Which path takes the MOST? Use the numbers from your table.

2. If you wanted to start earning money as fast as possible, which path would you choose? Give one reason from your table.
